

Small Family Style Assembly Preference

prc-small-family-style-assembly-preference

Leadership & Polity · Assembly Size · practice · minority_lineages · brethren distinctive

INSUFFICIENT

Supported across many Bible texts
Scripture does not engage the subject
No NT manuscript apparatus applies

Statement under examination

Small to mid-sized assemblies (sub-Dunbar) where members are known by name and elders can shepherd individually are preferable to mega-church structures.

In plain language

The verses behind this question use shepherding and oversight language. The Greek words are 'flock' (poimnion), 'to shepherd' (poimaino), 'overseer' (episkopos), 'Chief Shepherd' (archipoimen, which occurs only once in the whole New Testament, a hapax meaning a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), and 'to lead' (hegeomai), referring to those who lead. In John 10:14 the Good Shepherd knows his own using 'to know' (ginosko), a verb of personal, mutual knowledge. In 1 Peter 5 elders shepherd the flock willingly, not for gain, not domineering, but as examples. In Hebrews 13:17 leaders keep watch over souls and will give an account. Read together these texts paint a clear and consistent picture of what good oversight is like. It is personal, attentive, and accountable. Alongside this, a second group of texts is just as real. The New Testament repeatedly calls a congregation 'the church at someone's house', using the phrase 'at-the-house assembly' (kat oikon ekklesia) in Romans 16:5, 1 Corinthians 16:19, Colossians 4:15, and Philemon 2, shows believers breaking bread 'house by house' (kat oikon) in Acts 2:46 and Acts 5:42, and calls the whole body 'the household of God', from the words 'house or household' (oikos) and 'members of God's household' (oikeioi tou theou), in 1 Timothy 3:15 and Ephesians 2:19, with members addressed as 'brothers' (adelphoi). So home gatherings and family language are genuinely woven into the text. What the words still do not do is rank a small assembly above a large one. The very same book of Acts reports three thousand added in one day, about five thousand men, and 'tens of thousands' (myriades) of believers, and in Acts 5:42 the believers meet in the large temple courts and in homes at the same time, with neither scale called better. The Greek even has plain words for 'small' (mikros), 'great' (megas), and 'few' (oligos), yet none of them is ever applied to an assembly as a preference. So on the words alone the claim that smaller is preferable to larger is neither established nor refuted. The text speaks to the manner of care and the reality of home gatherings, not to a ceiling on size, so the verdict is left open.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0080	ἀδελφός	adelphos	brother	348
G0750	ἀρχιποίμην	archipoimen	chief shepherd	1
G1097	γινώσκω	ginosko	to know	223
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklesia	assembly	117
G1983	ἐπισκοπέω	episkopeō	to oversee/care for	
G1985	ἐπίσκοπος	episkopos	overseer	7
G2233	ἡγεομαι	hegeomai	to govern	28

G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2411	ιερόν	hieros	temple	
G3173	μέγας	megas	great	
G3398	μικρός	mikros	small	
G3461	μυριάς	urias	myriad	9
G3609	οἰκεῖος	oikeios	of one's household	3
G3614	οἰκία	oikia	home	
G3624	οἶκος	oikos	house	115
G3641	ὀλίγος	oligos	little/few	
G4128	πλῆθος	plēthos	multitude	
G4165	ποιμαίνω	poimaino	to shepherd	11
G4166	ποιμήν	poimēn	shepherd	
G4168	ποῖμνιον	poimnion	flock	5
G5505	χιλιάς	chilias	thousand	23

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Two real word-threads run through the cited and adjacent texts, but the vocabulary itself never ranks one above the other. One thread commends intimate, home-based, family-style gathering: churches meet 'house by house' (kat oikon), described as 'the church in someone's house' (Romans 16:5, 1 Corinthians 16:19, Colossians 4:15, Philemon 2), believers break bread 'house by house' (kat oikon) in Acts 2:46 and Acts 5:42, and the body is named 'house or household' (oikos) and 'members of God's household' (oikeioi tou theou), that is, the household of God (1 Timothy 3:15, Ephesians 2:19), with members addressed as 'brothers' (adelphoi). The other thread, inside the same book of Acts, scales upward without any negative comment: 'three thousand' (trischilioi) added in a single day (Acts 2:41), 'about five thousand' (chiliades pente) men (Acts 4:4), 'tens of thousands' (myriades) of believing Jews (Acts 21:20), and one 'assembly or church' (ekklesia) at Ephesus shepherded by a plurality of elders (Acts 20:28). The shepherding word-set ('flock', poimnion; 'to shepherd', poimaino; 'overseer', episkopos; the once-in-the-whole-Bible word 'Chief Shepherd', archipoimen, which is a hapax meaning a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible; and 'to know', ginosko, of mutual knowing) regulates the manner of oversight but quantifies no size. Decisively, the size adjectives the Bible does possess ('small', mikros; 'great', megas; 'few', oligos) are never applied to an assembly as a preference. The verdict is null because the vocabulary genuinely does not state a size ranking, not because two defensible readings of a size claim are in competition.

Scripture

John.10.14 · neutral · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G1097 γινώσκω, G4166 ποιμήν

Reasoning. The Good Shepherd says he 'knows' (ginosko) his own and his own 'know' (ginosko) him. The verb 'to know' (ginosko, Strong's G1097), which is widespread across the whole Bible at 223 New Testament occurrences, marks a relational, mutual knowing between shepherd and sheep as a quality of true shepherding. It describes the kind of knowing relationship, not a numerical ceiling on how many sheep the flock may contain.

Acts.20.28 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4168 ποιμνιον, G1985 ἐπίσκοπος, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Reasoning. Paul charges the Ephesian elders to attend to the whole 'flock' (poimnion) over which the Spirit set them as 'overseers' (episkopos), to shepherd the 'assembly or church' (ekklesia) of God. The construction commits one city-wide assembly (ekklesia) to a plurality of elders, but the nouns carry no size specification, and the same Ephesian assembly (ekklesia) is elsewhere portrayed as a sizeable body. Oversight here scales across a large assembly rather than capping it at a small number.

1Pet.5.2 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4165 ποιμαίνω, G4168 ποιμνιον

Reasoning. Peter commands the elders to 'shepherd' (poimanate, the aorist imperative form, that is, a one-off completed-action command, of the verb 'to shepherd', poimaino) the 'flock' (poimnion) of God among them, overseeing willingly and not for shameful gain. The mode of shepherding is regulated (willing, eager, exemplary) but the size of the 'flock' (poimnion) is left unstated.

1Pet.5.3 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4168 ποιμνιον

Reasoning. Elders are not to lord it over those allotted to them but to be 'examples or patterns' (typoi) to the 'flock' (poimnion). The constraint is on manner of rule, not domineering but a model, again a relational and ethical norm rather than a structural or numerical prescription.

1Pet.5.4 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0750 ἀρχιποίμην

Reasoning. When the 'Chief Shepherd' (archipoimen, a true hapax meaning a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible, with its single Bible-wide occurrence right here) appears, faithful elders receive an unfading crown of glory. The term frames human elders as under-shepherds accountable to Christ. Being a once-only word (hapax), its sense rests on the see-through compound 'chief' (archi) plus 'shepherd' (poimen) rather than on cross-Bible usage, and it bears on motive and accountability, not on how many sheep an under-shepherd may oversee.

Heb.13.17 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2233 ἡγέομαι

Reasoning. Believers are to obey and submit to their 'leaders' (hegoumenois, the participle form of hegeomai, to lead) who keep watch over their 'souls' (psychon) as those who will give an account. The participle 'keeping watch' (agrupnousin) implies attentive personal care, yet the text fixes the duty of vigilance, not a member count beyond which such vigilance would become impossible.

Rom.16.5 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3624 οἶκος, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Reasoning. Paul greets 'the assembly or church (ekklesia) that meets at their house' (ten kat oikon auton ekklesian). The phrase 'house by house' or 'at the house' (kat plus oikon, where kat is the preposition kata meaning 'down through' or 'at') locates an actual assembly in a private home. This is positive word-evidence that a real first-century gathering pattern was small and home-based, but the phrase reports where a church met. It does not contain any comparative or preference term ranking that pattern above a larger one.

1Cor.16.19 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3624 οἶκος, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Reasoning. Aquila and Prisca send greetings 'together with the assembly or church (ekklesia) at their house' (syn te kat oikon auton ekklesia). The same 'at-the-house assembly' formula (kat oikon ekklesia) recurs, confirming that a house-meeting assembly was an established and recognizable category. The wording describes the venue and scale of one gathering without legislating it as preferable.

1Tim.3.15 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G3624 οἶκος, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Reasoning. The assembly is identified as 'house or household of God' (oikos theou), which is the 'assembly or church' (ekklesia) of the living God. The metaphor of 'house or household' (oikos) here is family-related and architectural (pillar and base of the truth), framing the church as a household, but 'house or household' (oikos) in this verse is the family-of-God image, not a statement that the gathering must be physically small. The family sense and the size question are distinct.

Eph.2.19 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G3609 οἰκεῖος, G2316 θεός

Reasoning. Believers are no longer strangers but 'members of the household of God' (oikeioi tou theou), from the word 'household member' (oikeios, Strong's G3609, with three Bible-wide occurrences). The family-and-household vocabulary is clear and intentional. It establishes that the people of God are a family, which warrants family-style treatment of one another, but 'household member' (oikeios) names belonging and kinship, not a maximum congregation size.

Acts.2.46 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3624 οἶκος, G2411 ἱερόν

Reasoning. The early believers continued daily 'in the temple' (en to hiero) in the temple courts and broke bread 'house by house' (kat oikon). The same verse places the large public gathering (the 'temple', hieron) and the intimate home gathering ('house by house', kat oikon) side by side as at-the-same-time, fits-together practices. The text presents both scales together and ranks neither above the other.

Acts.21.20 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: hyperbole

Key terms. G3461 μυριάς, G0080 ἀδελφός

Reasoning. The Jerusalem leaders tell Paul how many 'tens of thousands' (myriades, the plural of murias, meaning ten-thousand units) of believing Jews there are, addressing him as 'brother' (adelphe, the vocative or direct-address form of adelphos). Here the family-style address ('brother', adelphos) coexists with an explicitly enormous number ('tens of thousands', myriades). The same Bible that supplies house-church and household-family language also reports a believing community in the tens of thousands without treating its size as a defect.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.2.46	Acts.5.42	openbible	17
Acts.2.46	Acts.20.7	openbible	12
Rom.16.5	Phlm.1.2	openbible	7
Col.4.15	Rom.16.5	openbible	6
1Cor.16.19	Acts.18.2	openbible	6
Eph.2.19	Gal.6.10	openbible	20

John.10.14	John.10.27	tsk	1
Acts.20.28	Acts.20.29	tsk	1
1Pet.5.3	Ezek.34.4	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Acts.2.41 · addressed

About 'three thousand' (trischilioi) souls were added in a single day to the one Jerusalem community, which then continued together. A flock numbering thousands under apostolic oversight shows that the shepherding and household vocabulary does not entail small numbers, which cuts against reading the anchor verses as prescribing a sub-Dunbar ceiling, that is, a cap based on the Dunbar number (a hypothesized roughly 150-person cognitive limit on stable relationships).

Acts.4.4 · addressed

The number of believing men became 'about five thousand' (chiliades pente, literally 'five thousands' from chilia meaning a thousand-unit). A second explicit large figure in the same narrative confirms that the rapidly growing single community was not treated as too big to be a true church, so the size preference is not derivable from the words.

Acts.21.20 · addressed

Believing Jews are counted in 'tens of thousands' (myriades), and Paul is addressed as 'brother' (adelphos), in the same breath. Family-style language and an enormous head count coexist, so the family or household vocabulary cannot by itself imply that small is preferable to large.

Acts.5.42 · addressed

Daily teaching happened both 'in the temple' (en to hiero) in the temple courts and 'house by house' (kat oikon). The text endorses the two scales at the same time rather than ranking the home gathering above the large public assembly, which is exactly the comparison the proposition asserts and the words decline to make.

Acts.20.28 · addressed

The single 'assembly or church' (ekklesia) at Ephesus is committed to a plurality of elders and is elsewhere portrayed as a large city-wide church, so the verse used to support intimate oversight also evidences oversight scaled across a sizeable assembly, leaving the size preference word-wise undetermined.

Concordance traversed

G4168, G4165, G1985, G1983, G1577, G1097, G0750, G2233, G3624, G3614, G3609, G0080, G3461, G5505, G4128, G3398, G3173, G3641

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

A direct query of the word-data store returned zero VariantUnit nodes attached to the anchor verses (Acts 20:28, 1 Peter 5:2, John 10:14) and to the house-church verses (Romans 16:5, 1 Corinthians 16:19, Colossians 4:15, Philemon 2, Acts 2:46). All cited verses lie outside the loaded window of the ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants), since the CBGM coherence-based genealogical method window currently covers only 3 John. The apparatus marks in the source text, for example the 'of God' (theou) versus 'of the Lord' (kuriou) reading at Acts 20:28, touch the 'from-X' grammatical form (genitive of source) marking ownership of the church. They do not touch the shepherding, household, or size vocabulary on which any reading of this proposition would turn. The verdict is therefore robust under textual variants.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked

descriptive_pastoral_norm: neutral · Reading the shepherding texts as describing the quality of oversight, that is, personal knowledge through 'knowing' (ginosko), vigilance, exemplary care, yields no claim about congregation size. The size preference is then neither affirmed nor denied at the word level because the words address manner, not magnitude.

house_church_household_pattern: disputed · In its strongest form this reading notes that the New Testament repeatedly and deliberately names an assembly as the church in someone's house, 'at-the-house assembly' (kat oikon ekklesia) in Romans 16:5, 1 Corinthians 16:19, Colossians 4:15, and Philemon 2, shows believers breaking bread 'house by house' (kat oikon) in Acts 2:46 and Acts 5:42, and calls the body 'house or household of God', that is, 'house or household' (oikos) and 'members of God's household' (oikeioi tou theou), in 1 Timothy 3:15 and Ephesians 2:19, with members as 'brothers' (adelphoi). A reader can fairly hold that this dense, recurring home-and-family vocabulary commends an intimate, family-scale gathering as the apostolic texture of church life. The reading is genuinely grounded in the words, but it remains an inference about scale that the texts themselves never convert into a comparative preference, because the same books place 'house by house' (kat oikon) beside temple-court crowds and 'tens of thousands' (myriades) without ranking them.

size_silent_lexicon: neutral · The Bible possesses size adjectives, 'small' (mikros), 'great' (megas), 'few' (oligos), and never applies any of them to an 'assembly or church' (ekklesia) or 'flock' (poimnion) as a value judgment. The vocabulary that could express a size preference exists but is not deployed for assemblies, so the silence is a genuine non-statement rather than an accidental gap, and a word-level verdict on the comparison cannot be grounded.

The anchor verses constrain the manner of eldership, that is, knowing, watching, not lording it over, giving account. A second cluster of texts establishes a real house-meeting and household-family practice. Neither cluster legislates assembly size. Moving from personal shepherding or family-style language to a maximum head count requires an extra premise, a cognitive or relational cap, that the biblical vocabulary does not supply, and the same Bible reports communities in the thousands and tens of thousands without censure.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does the biblical shepherding, oversight, and household vocabulary specify or imply a preferred size for a local assembly, such that smaller assemblies are favored over larger ones?

The original stem is preloaded in two ways. First, the word 'preferable' encodes a comparative value judgment before any text is consulted. Second, the parenthetical 'sub-Dunbar' imports a modern sociological category, the Dunbar number, a hypothesized roughly 150-person cognitive cap on stable relationships, which is foreign to the biblical vocabulary. The neutralized form asks whether the vocabulary itself bears on size at all. The verdict was derived against the original stem and returns null because, after pulling the full Bible-wide distribution of the shepherding word-set, the house-church formula 'at-the-house assembly' (kat oikon ekklesia), the household words 'house or household' (oikos) and 'household member' (oikeios), and the large-number words 'three thousand' (trischilioi), 'thousands' (chiliades), and 'tens of thousands' (myriades), the data answers the neutral question in the negative. The vocabulary describes both intimate and large gatherings and ranks neither. VERDICT-CHANGED: the verdict is unchanged from the prior file and remains null on strengthened, directly queried evidence.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.16.5
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.2.46
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.21.20
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.20.28
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4168
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3609
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Pet.5.2

cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Acts.2.46
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Pet.5.3

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

cross-tradition-divergent